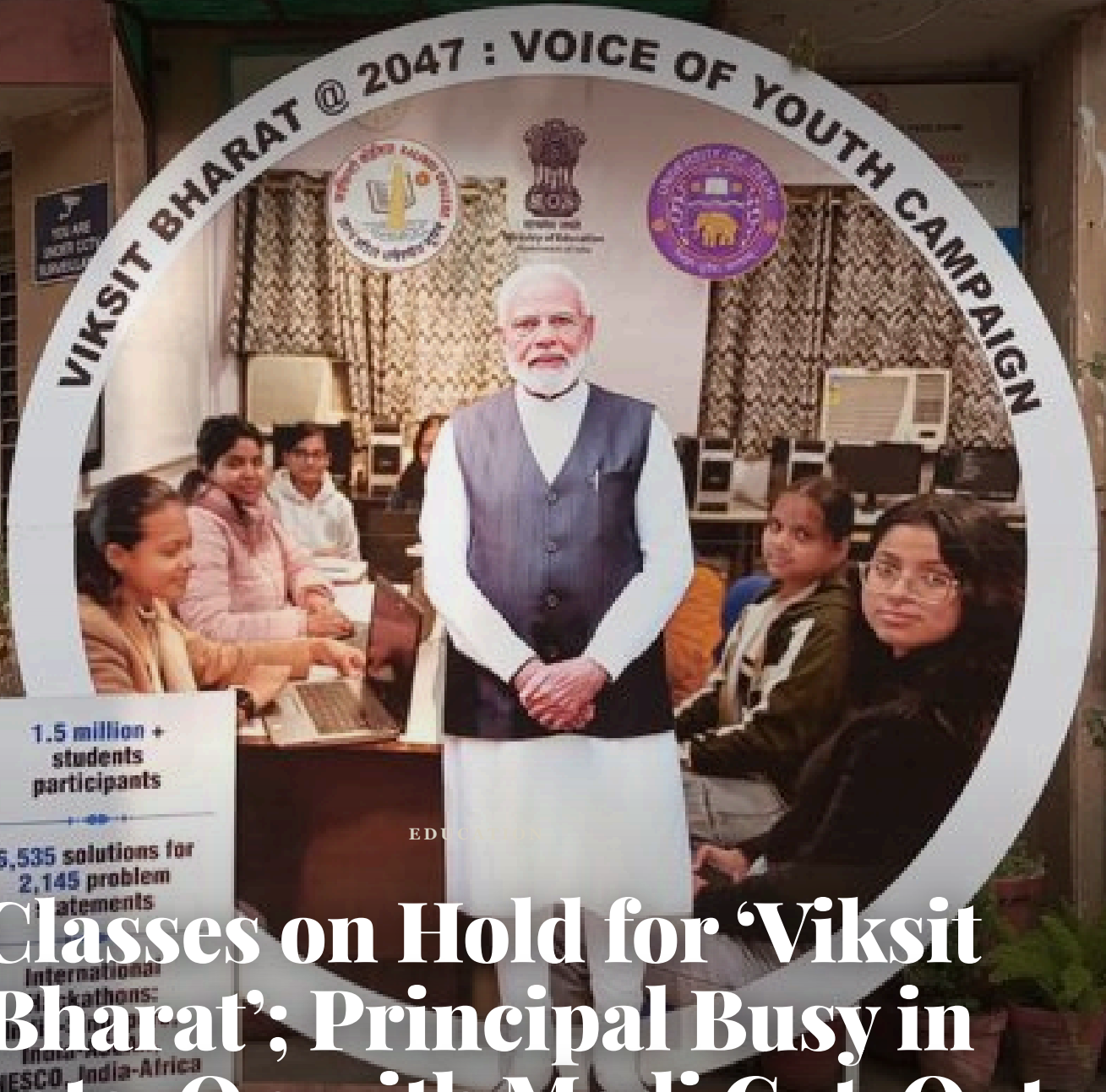




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Classes on Hold for 'Viksit Bharat'; Principal Busy in Photo-Op with Modi Cut-Out

At Kalindi College, New Delhi, students were told attendance would be marked for participation in the BJP government's 'Viksit Bharat' initiative — events scheduled during class hours, as the college principal posed for photographs at a Modi cut-out. A ground report on the line between government scheme and institutional compulsion.

BY MOULI SHARMA

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ABOUT

The Voice Express

The Truth Takes Time.

EDITOR IN CHIEF

Mouli

WEB DEVELOPER

Mitali (Aayat Mahnoor)

CONTACT

thevoiceexpress@proton.me

WEBSITE

<https://thevoiceexpress.in>

LOCATION

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‘Attendance’ to be marked for participation in ‘Viksit Bharat’ events taking place during class hours.



PHOTOGRAPH BY THE VOICE EXPRESS

14th February 2024, New Delhi: The current phase of the government’s ‘Viksit Bharat’ (*Developed India*) initiative, “a nationwide campaign to raise awareness through outreach activities to achieve saturation of schemes of Govt. of India across the country covering all [Local Bodies]^[1],” is taking place in educational institutes, including higher education institutes like the University of Delhi.

From hours-long photo ops, workshops, surveys & quizzes (take the Viksit Bharat quiz on the Hamara Sankalp Viksit Bharat^[2] website to get a certificate from PM Modi himself!) all culminating in the Viksit Bharat Pledge, a wide range of ‘events’ under the sun are taking place in various colleges of Delhi University under the aegis of internal quality assessment committees, media societies, or department management. Some colleges show no participation at all, implying that none of these are regulation procedures, & are being informally implemented. At one Kalindi College, the campaign has taken over day-hours with many of the activities directly clashing with & being given priority over lectures, & overworked faculty canceling several of the rest. But here’s the catch; attendance is still being marked.

With DU’s allotment of 5% of student’s final grade ending up at null for attendance below 67%, & arbitrary cancellation of classes around the year by professors being a regular & consequence-less matter, attending or not attending a 3-hour event can mean the difference between having ‘attended’ or not ‘attended’ 3 lectures at a time on paper, none of which were in fact conducted. This is unfair to students who travel long distances daily Kalindi, one of DU’s many sans-hostel colleges, leading to a large number of students ignoring the ‘mandatory’ attendance of these workshops to stay home & study.

“I haven’t been attending the events. I’m not interested. How many Youth India schemes have come before this? Have they ever improved anything?” says a student of Kalindi College’s Journalism Department, which is the most significantly impacted. One of the more recent departments to suffer mass dismissals & replacements after interviews for permanent faculty, KC’s small team of 8 professors is involved not only with its heavily stacked schedule of Viksit Bharat events within

With DU's infamous academic calendar already lagging behind in the 2023-24 session as always (the even semester began a staggering 16 days after the commencement date marked on the university's initial calendar, delaying examinations till the last week of May), ongoing faculty interviews, & the university being in the transition period of the NEP, students and faculty are already stretched thin in an attempt to complete syllabi, & these generic, unnecessary, school-like activities - being carried out under the guise of improving the reach of government schemes to secluded communities - are taking precious time away from near graduate students.

But instances like these aren't limited to the University of Delhi. The participation statistics of the Viksit Bharat Mission quoted on their official website continue to grow, & the reality of this 'participation' as far as being conducted in higher education institutes is that is forced, involuntary, & consistently being carried out at the threat of academic sabotage. At the capital's Netaji Subhash Technological University, students were handed out 'Viksit Bharat' promotional tasks as 'assignments,' failing to complete which would mean wasting their previous semester.

"We had to send in some idea related to viksit bharat. The college people wouldn't return our previous semester marksheets otherwise." says a third-year B.Tech student at NSUT's east campus.

This is time that the Universities - especially DU, which is Centre-Administered & in this state of tumult & mismanagement under direct action of the Centre itself - should be given to settle into new policies, assimilate new staff - many of whom in DU are teaching higher academics & research for the first time - & focus on what is ultimately their only goal: teaching. Academics, the upper variant of which one could argue is what is most fundamental to India's 'development.' Instead, classes are not only taking a backseat in the face of entertaining & carrying out government campaigns (also read (to be updated): *"What is a 'Viksit Bharat' & Where Can I get One?"*) but also doing so all while maintaining the facade of continuing with regular academics through fraudulent attendance records.

What business do the Universities partaking in these activities have to do so? What business does the government have making them?

Of the three objectives listed out for the Hamara Sankalp Viksit Bharat campaign, only one can be speculated (or is even possible) to be what Universities like NSUT & DU are trying to achieve: "Dissemination of information and generating awareness about schemes." What part of disseminating information about government schemes is a filmmaking workshop for a bachelor's level media course. What part of 'reaching the unreachable' is a guest lecture on social media marketing by 'Mr. Varun'?

What part of saturating government schemes is taking a selfie with a cardboard cutout of Narendra Modi & uploading it to a gov.in website?

Source: TVE

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Mouli Sharma

CONTRIBUTOR

Mouli Sharma is a journalist, freelance illustrator, and writer from New Delhi, India. She is a published photojournalist & illustrator, having been featured in The Hindu College Gazette, & the quarterly Pink Disco. Mouli took over as the Editor of The Voice Express (<https://thevoiceexpress.github.io/e-mag/>) back in September 2023.

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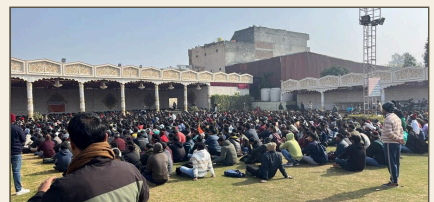
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[1] a nationwide campaign to raise awareness through outreach activities to achieve saturation of schemes of Govt. of India across the country covering all [Local Bodies]

[2] Hamara Sankalp Viksit Bharat